charge in.

Meanwhile, and in stark contrast, Ferishta writes of how Chand Bibi ‘appeared with a veil on her head . . . [and] caused guns to be brought to bear on the assailants, and stones to be hurled on them’. At night, while the Mughals dilly-dallied, ‘she stood by the workmen, and caused the breach to be filled up nine feet before daylight with wood, stones, and earth, and dead carcasses’.[76]

Two days after the breach was made, Murad had lost his strategic advantage and left. He had a face-saving truce and a great deal of booty, but Ahmednagar remained free.

By the following year, the three great Deccani kingdoms, Ahmednagar, Bijapur and Golconda, had formed an alliance against the Mughals. This time, it was Abdur Rahim, with Sulaiman’s grandson Shahrukh, who led the troops. He barely avoided defeat; worse, he managed to alienate the Mughals’ only Deccani ally, Khandesh – Abdur Rahim’s troops plundered the king of Khandesh’s camp when he died fighting on the Mughal side.

The next year, 1598, began with news that Abdur Rahim had given up on the whole affair and gone home.

Akbar was fed up. He sent messengers to tick Abdur Rahim off and bring Murad to court. Murad wouldn’t come. It was Abdur Rahim who arrived, instead; and he was followed, within two days, by Qilij Khan.

The previous year, Akbar had sent his youngest son, Daniyal, to govern Allahabad, and Qilij Khan was to advise and assist him. Daniyal was much more amiable than the imperious Murad. Salim describes him with affection, as a good-looking young man of poetic temperament, fond of composing Hindi verse. This was not enough, evidently, to win him loyal courtiers – or maybe neither Murad nor Daniyal wanted to be watched over by their father’s appointees. At any rate, Qilij Khan was ‘somewhat displeased’ with Daniyal, much like Abdur Rahim with Murad, and had abandoned him.[77]

Akbar, meanwhile, was having no better luck with the one prince who remained under his own charge – his eldest, the boon of his prayers, Salim.

In January of this very year, 1598, news had arrived that Abdullah of Turan had died. For fourteen years, Akbar and Abdullah had kept covetous eyes on each other’s kingdoms – and it was to Akbar, of course, that fate